

WINGS UNLEASHED
A Dassault Rafale Marine takes off from the French aircraft carrier *Charles de Gaulle*, Nov. 28, 2024

DEFENCE | RAFALE-M

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INS VIKRANT'S DECKS WILL SOON HAVE ADVANCED RAFALE MARINES, PROMISING TO

Finally, the Indian Navy has got its weapon of choice. In a move to bolster its maritime dominance, India has set its sights on the Dassault Rafale Marine (Rafale-M), a game-changing addition to the navy's arsenal. On April 9, the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), the highest body on security matters led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the procurement of 26 Rafale-M fighter jets worth Rs 63,000 crore. It is India's biggest foreign defence procurement to date; the 36 Rafales bought for the Indian Air Force (IAF) in 2016 cost Rs 59,000 crore. A government-to-government deal with France will be signed by the end of this month in the presence of French defence minister Sébastien Lecornu in New Delhi. The advanced 4.5-generation jets are destined to operate from the decks of INS *Vikrant*, India's first indigenous aircraft carrier. The delivery is expected to start from 2029, with all 26 jets expected to arrive by 2031.

The deal is for 22 single-seater jets and four twin-seater trainer variants, along with weapons, simulators, spares, crew training and five years of logistics support. Under the agreement, 10 of the IAF's 36 Rafales will also be retrofitted for buddy-buddy refuelling—transfer of aviation fuel between airborne aircraft—extending their operational range.

The Rafale-M deal underscores India's commitment to counter the rising naval ambitions of China and any misadventures by its strategic partner Pakistan in the Indo-Pacific. Naval experts believe that as tensions simmer in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR), the Rafale-M—considered the world's most advanced carrier-borne fighter jet—will redefine India's strategic reach, equipping the navy with unmatched capability in terms of strike, air defence and reconnaissance missions. The Rafale-M can also be deployed from land-based airfields. After all the aircraft are delivered, India will have 62 Rafale fighter jets.

As carrier-borne aircraft, the Rafale-M will complement the navy's existing Russian-origin Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-29K fleet. Though it increases the carrier force's operational arc, the procurement